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The Whites think too much

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The custom of mock-kinship or joking relationship (parenté à plaisanterie) we interpret as the Dogon do, regarding it as a special form of greeting. Mock-kinship means that individuals who are socially close or on familiar terms with each other, or are members of large groups (villages, tribes, two different clans) are obligated to exchange, as soon as they meet, instead of a greeting, mocking quips, vulgar and obscene remarks or even blows. This is behavior that toward others would be regarded as a serious insult, but is in this instance a necessary courtesy and a joke. One finds this custom among many African tribes.

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The Dogon say: That is my mangu and I am his mangu. All Dogon have a mock-kinship with the Bozo, members of a tribe of fishermen who live somewhat beyond, on the Niger. One day, the dignified Abinu greeted an unfamiliar chauffeur who had driven an official to Bongo, with the words: "I know you, you're not a Bozo at all, you're only a slave of the Bozo and your father was a perfectly ordinary slave. Otherwise you would not have to swallow dust as a chauffeur. You would have enough fish to eat and could stay at home. What are you doing here getting on our nerves." The Bozo laughed and answered in kind. Numerous legends indicate that the Bozo once united with the Dogon in a blood-fraternity or blood—kinship. "A Dogon chief, in war, had compassion with the starving child of a Bozo. He cut meat from the calf of his own leg, gave it to the child to eat and saved its life."

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If boys and girls have a mock-relationship with one another while they are sharing some work such as harvesting po, (21) the innuendos are even more obscene. Couples who on other occasions might have sexual relations seem obliged to divert their feelings by joking. Kinfolk who must be treated in this way are the ones who, in other circumstances, might be thought of as a married couple, such as the brother's wives or those 68 with whom a sexual approach would be the same as incest, such as the wife of the maternal uncle and the wife of the grandfather (nani) who is, of course, like a father because he gave vital energy to his grandson.

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It is assumed that sexual feelings have been aroused. Because these feelings are forbidden they are on a par with incestuous desires. The object of these desires, the mother, is projected into the mythical past or transferred to other women of the present ■ 60 68 cont. family who might take the part of one's own mother. Between the Dogon and the Bozo, who are mangu to each other, sex and marriage are strictly forbidden. Aggressive impulses flowing to the male mock-relative in a jokingly distorted form reflect more or less clearly that the animosity is directed toward one's own father by the disturbing rival of the mother. The especially strict prohibition against killing a mock-relative completes the picture of how the Oedipus complex applies in its broadest sense: by interdicts against incest and killing. It explains why, according to legend, the two mocking each other are usually regarded as the paternal family and the maternal family. On the second day of the death rites, the mangu will come in appropriate disguises to bring back the deceased, imitating the ritual appropriate to the relatives of the deceased's mother.

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(21). Po = Digitaria exilis. See footnote 21 on p. 27.

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